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"FLYING SAUCERS" REPORTED SEEN OVER SPAIN -- Athens, I Kathimerini, 19 Jul 53

Paris (Special Services) -- According to reports from Madrid, "flying saucers" were seen during the last few days in [an unidentified area of] Spain.

Witnesses stated that a luminous, circular object, emitting a red reflection and flying like a jet plane, was seen flying noiselessly in a northwest direction. Inhabitants of the village of San Martin Valdeiglesias also saw a luminous, spherical object, which disappeared toward the west after being observed for a considerable length of time.

SEE LUMINOUS, ROCKET-SHAPED OBJECT IN SKY OVER DRAMA -- Salonica, Makedonia, 13 Aug 53

It was reported from Drama, Greece, that a luminous, rocket-shaped object was noted at 2225 hours on 11 August 1953 in the southeastern part of the sky over that city. The object flew at a rather low altitude and was seen remaining stationary in the air for 3-4 minutes, after which it disappeared.

SEE STRANGE FLYING OBJECT NEAR CASABLANCA -- Athens, Eleftheria, 5 Sep 53

According to a report from Oued Zem, a town southeast of Casablanca, French Morocco, some of the inhabitants heard a thunderous noise on the night of 2 September 1953. The next day, two shepherds said they had seen a flying object, lighted in many colors and flying at great speed.

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Experts Say Object Was Daylight Meteorite

Both the Defense Staff and the Air Staff were working feverishly on Friday (18 December) to solve the mystery of the "flying lozenge." They arrived at no definite result, but the experts are mostly of the opinion that the observed object was a daylight meteorite. The possibility that it was a balloon or an unknown type of foreign aircraft is not ruled out, however. The theory of a meteorite was put forth by one of the persons in Sweden best acquainted with the region, Bertil Lindblad of the observatory in Lund.

According to Lindblad, precisely in December the earth passes a swarm of meteors known as the Geminids. The maximum occurred on 13 December. Studies of the meteors have shown that just at the time of day at which the object was seen -- about 1500 hours -- the meteors are approaching the earth at an angle of 3 degrees which means that their path is nearly parallel to the earth's surface. The direction of the meteors is from north to south with a displacement of 17 degrees which also seems to agree with the observations made. In space, meteors have a speed of 36 kilometers per second, but the speed is reduced very greatly when they come into the vicinity of the earth. It has not heretofore been possible to observe meteors during the day so it is not known how they look in daylight. When the earth passed the same meteor swarm last year, a lone meteor was observed some days after the swarm had disappeared. That meteor was plainly a straggler. It was observed at night, however, and therefore gave off a weak, red glow. It fell also at an entirely different angle since it was a different time of day.

Captain Källenius of the Defense Staff stated that other possible explanations of the phenomenon have not been written off by any means. To be sure, no Swedish balloons have been sent up, but propaganda and weather balloons have been sent up from both Germany and Denmark. With the type of wind and weather prevailing in recent days, it would have been possible for a balloon to have been driven over Sweden. Captain Christiernsson and his mechanic, Olle Johansson, stated in their report that the speed of the object approached that of sound; however, there is great difficulty in judging speeds of suddenly appearing objects, even for experienced observers. Captain Källenius commented that if a balloon prior to its observation had soared to a great altitude, it might have lost some of its gas, giving it a flat form.

In some quarters, Captain Christiernsson's report has been regarded as a prank. The Defense Staff, however, does not consider it a prank. Christiernsson, on returning from another flight to Malmö on Friday, gave heated assurances that his report was the absolute truth. He said, "To be sure, I joke a bit, but one does not joke about things like this. I saw something and reported my observations. What it was, I do not know."(2)

Object Stated to Be Advertising Balloon

The mysterious "flying lozenge" over Håssleholm was probably neither a meteor nor a robot weapon, it was more likely an advertising balloon for a Skaane perfume firm. The object was observed at 1500 on Thursday (17 December) and on the same day between 1200 and 1300, Director Bertil Dahlström of Malmö had been up at Äsphult on Linderödsåsen, some myriameters south of Håssleholm, to release 300 advertising balloons.

On Saturday evening (19 December) Dahlström telephoned Dagens Nyheter's Malmö office and said, "With all certainty, it is one of our balloons which the flyers saw. On Thursday noon, we sent up over 300 balloons of various colors. Their sizes varied from 15 to 30 centimeters in diameter. According to what we know from previous occasions, the balloons ought to rise 1,000 meters and

maybe still higher, depending on the weather. To each balloon was attached an advertisement card which the finder was to return to the firm in Malmö in exchange for a bottle of cologne. Some cards have already been returned from finders with addresses in Håssleholm, so it is clear that the balloons were driven by the prevailing winds to the place where the flyers observed the mysterious lozenge."

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As of Saturday evening, the Air Staff did not know about the Skaane balloons. On the other hand, the Air Staff had received a telephone call from another person in Malmö, radio technician Lundblad. On the day before the observation (16 December), he had sent up three weather balloons of a current model. The wind was so strong and in such a direction that it is not likely that any of the three balloons could have remained over Skaane. Meteorological balloons are from 1 to 2 meters in diameter.

Whether the perfume advertising balloons, which are considerably smaller than meteorological balloons, could, through angles of refraction and radiation of light, take on the appearance and size which Captain Christiernsson reported the object to be, is a question which cannot be answered until detailed calculations are made. Very likely, composite photographs and other techniques will be utilized to determine the matter.

No new observations have been reported during Saturday (19 December), and the experts are now working with the material which came in earlier. Telephone calls have been received from a number of persons with new theories, some of which will be tested. In the meantime, the balloon theory seems to have been strengthened through the latest reports from Skaane.(3)

SOURCES

1. Dagens Nyheter, 18 Dec 53
2. Ibid., 19 Dec 53
3. Ibid., 20 Dec 53

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